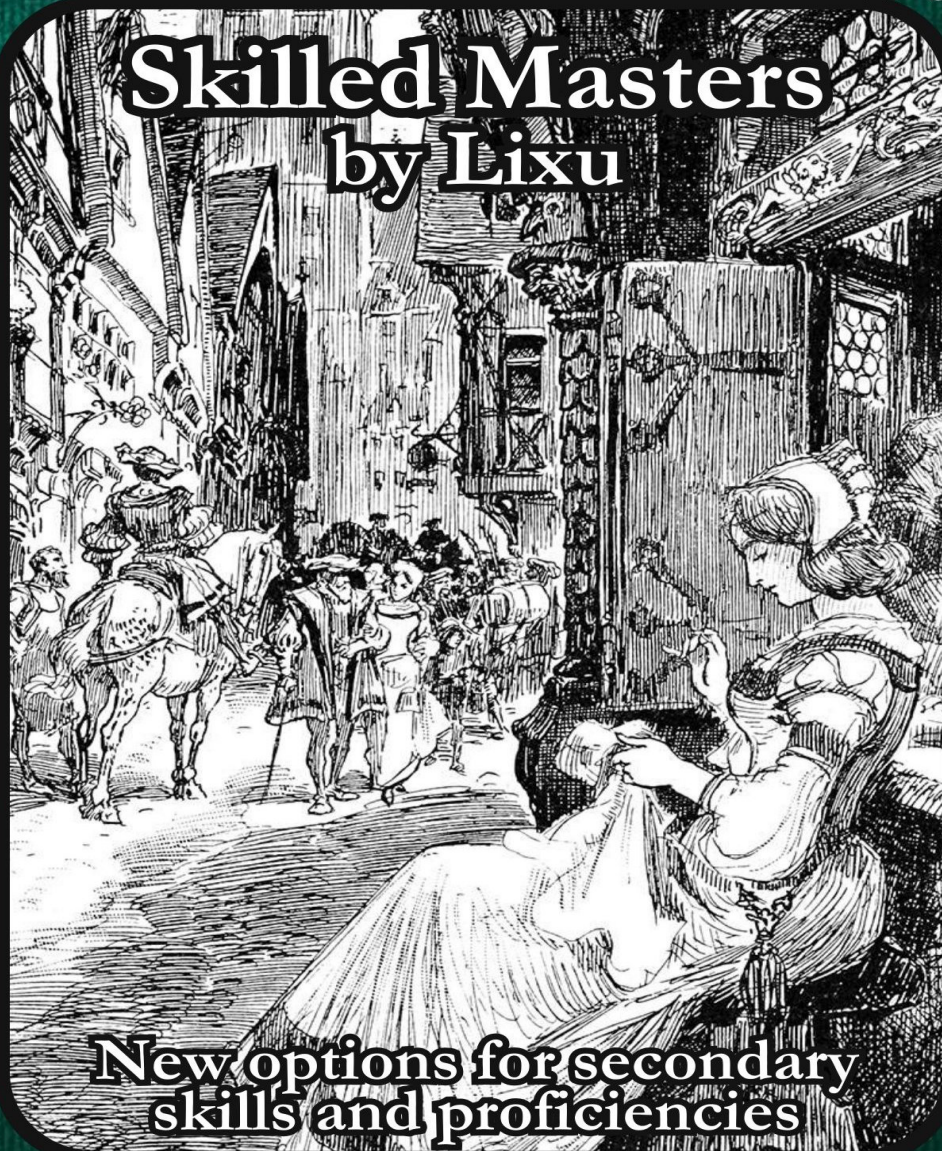


APPENDIX L

#6

Skilled Masters by Lixu



New options for secondary
skills and proficiencies

DESIGNED FOR USE WITH
**OLD-SCHOOL
ESSENTIALS**

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Art pieces and assets are available under public domain

**Although compatible with any old school edition, this booklet is meant to be used
with Old School Essentials™**

Foreword

A contentious element in the evolution of the game was the introduction of a skill system. Initially starting as way to further diversify and specialize characters, the introduction of skills had two effects: First, It further complexified the game by adding an additional sub-system on top of the already pre-existing race, class, combat and magic systems, and even though it didn't take too much time and effort to integrate, it certainly added another layer of complexity, while paradoxically making characters less competent compared to how they were before with the “assumed competence” of player characters dictated by class and race. The second consequence is that by introducing skills, it introduced the idea of “button-based gameplay”, meaning that instead of using descriptions and referee negotiations, now players would just look to their character sheets for the appropriate skill and then just roll it away.

This, as you might imagine, is one of the main factors that led to the development of modern day role playing, and although many other design principles took part in its surge and further predominance, it is true that in the mechanical aspect, skill systems were a big part of that. But what if there could be a way to introduce the idea of non-combat skills while avoiding the negative consequences? Perhaps, and this booklet is an attempt at that, perfect for introduction on your games on any B/X based system, *Old School Essentials or OSE™* being the preferred one for this booklet. The goal for this system is to solve the issue of character diversity, and assumed knowledge, while also appealing to a process usually not mentioned when attempting to create a living, breathing world, that of incentivizing players engagement with the setting itself.



Proficiencies

Similar to the system introduced in advanced 1st edition, proficiencies in certain skills are introduced to denote the character's standing in society, their talents and testament to their growth during their life as adventurers.

These proficiencies are divided into five categories:

- **Weapons:** Those related to the use of weapons.
- **Artisan:** Related to the creation of items.
- **Non-Weapon:** General knowledge skills that are applicable outside of combat.
- **Survival:** For actions performed in the wilderness for the survival of the group.
- **Languages:** Rules given for the learning of new languages through play.

Rules for each type of category, and what being proficient means, are going to be provided, which could be used in conjunction or alternative for your games.

Initial Proficiencies

Some categories are going to provide variables for starting proficiencies at level 1. However, the commonality among them is that the main goal is acquiring these skills through play and not from the start.

Mastering Proficiencies

Additional rules will be provided for how a character improves upon their pre-existing skills, how long it will take them to improve, plus any other requirements, prioritizing in-game time during which any character must spend their downtime practicing their skills.

Special Requirements

Certain types of proficiencies will require a special quest or level requirement to be acquired or improved upon, to which tools for these quests will be provided to assist referees willing to assign them to their players.



Weapon Proficiencies

These serve as a variant for the Weapon proficiencies rules present in *Old School Essentials Advanced*TM, using the following premises:

Martial, Semi-Martial & Non-Martial

Similar to OSETM, the nomenclature of martial, semi-martial and non-martial classes determine the benefit of being proficient in a weapon. For those unfamiliar, the categories are as follows:

- **Martial classes:** Gain an improvement to their THAC0 and saves every 3 levels (e.g. fighter).
- **Semi-martial classes:** Gain an improvement to their THAC0 and saves every 4 levels (e.g. thief).
- **Non-martial classes:** Gain an improvement to their THAC0 and saves every 5 levels (e.g. magic-user).

Weapon Proficiency Progression

Characters improve their skill with individual weapons through regular and meaningful use. Each weapon tracks its own training independently, and only the selected weapons may advance in rank. Characters advance in rank as they accumulate practice and reach the appropriate character level, detailed on the table next page according to the following principles:

Training Days: Each day in which the weapon is used effectively in combat or practiced for at least an hour counts as a meaningful use. A character may record only one meaningful use per in-game day.

Rank Advancement: A character's skill with a weapon increases through several ranks. Advancement requires meeting the listed number of training days for that rank (see chart) and reaching a specific character level. Higher ranks may require the completion of a special quest, as determined by the Referee.

Per-Weapon Tracking: Training is recorded separately for each weapon. Characters may advance on one weapon per day, and may choose to advance only a limited number of weapons, depending on their class.

- **Martial Classes:** May advance in up to four weapons.
- **Semi-Martial Classes:** May advance in up to two weapons.
- **Non-Martial Classes:** May advance in one weapon.

Adding Weapons: If a character wishes to begin advancement in a new weapon beyond their limit, they must first abandon advancement in another, with previously earned ranks in the abandoned weapon being lost.

Benefits for Martial Classes

Martial classes possess the training and discipline to push weapon mastery further than other adventurers. Whenever they advance in rank with a chosen weapon, they gain a +1 bonus to damage rolls with that weapon, on top of the benefits acquired from rank advancement.

Weapon Rank Advancement Table

Rank	Requirements	Benefit
Familiar	Having seen the weapon used once	None
Competent	40 days + 3rd Level	+1 to attack rolls
Skilled	120 days + 6th Level + Special Quest	+1 to damage rolls
Master	365 days + 9th Level + Special Quest	+1 to attack or damage rolls

Non-Proficient Attacks

Semi-martial and non-martial classes that wield a weapon not allowed for them (e.g: a sword for a magic-user) receive a -4 penalty on attack rolls until they advance to skilled rank.

Starting Proficiencies (Optional Rules)

Optionally, a referee may allow 1st level characters of a martial class to start with a weapon proficiency at competent rank.

Special Quest Generation

A special quest represents a focused journey of growth in which a character seeks experiences that cannot be gained through simple practice or routine combat. Each quest is built on three core principles: challenge, intent and transformation, making the journey leave a permanent mark on the technique, spirit, or understanding of the weapon. To assist on quest generation, the following table may be used by the referee:

Special Quest Ideas Table

d8	Quest Idea
1	Seek Mentor: Find a skilled master in a remote location willing to teach you advanced techniques.
2	Pilgrimage: Travel to a sacred or historically important site tied to your weapon's
3	Defeat Rival: Confront and overcome a rival warrior whose style challenges your own.
4	Hunt Monster: Track and slay a dangerous creature whose unique traits test your weapon's capabilities
5	Slay Enemies: Engage and defeat 2d8+4 hostile foes, wielding only your weapon and dealing always the finishing blow.
6	Forge Weapon: Craft, reforge, or enhance a weapon using rare materials or methods.
7	Retrieve Relic: Recover a lost artifact or divine relic, wielding only your weapon.
8	Rescue: Save an endangered person or ally.

Artisan Proficiencies

These refer to the abilities and knowledge of creating objects and equipment useful for adventuring. The process of creating these items rely on two steps: gathering materials and crafting.

Gathering Materials

To gather the required materials for crafting an item, one can either buy them or gather them in the wilderness, according to the following rulings:

Buying Materials: The costs for material are 10% its listed purchase price (e.g. A 3 gp dagger has its materials priced at 3 sp).

Gathering Materials: When traveling the wilderness, the character may perform a check to gather the materials required for one item. Some materials may not be easily available through this method, like metals (For more details, see survival proficiencies).

Artisan Proficiency Progression

In this system, by being proficient one gains the capacity of recognizing an item, its creation techniques, even appraising it at a glance and naturally crafting it. Crafting is resolved through daily checks until they accumulate the required number of successes to complete and mastery in the many disciplines progresses through some requirements, moving from novice to finally master, according to the following principles:

Number of Artisan Proficiencies:

Combined with non-weapon proficiencies and survival skills, a character may learn up to four, but only one may reach mastery.

Starting Proficiencies (Optional Rules):

Ideally none, but referees have the option of granting one at lvl. 1 at competent rank.

Crafting Checks: Items are crafted through repeated focused attempts rather than a single roll. Each attempt is made once per day through a d6 roll, with a 2-in-6 chance of success. Once the required number of successes is reached, the item is completed. Failed rolls represent lost effort, and not necessarily mean lost materials.

Crafting in the wild: Crafting is assumed to be done in a settlement. Crafting in the wilderness decreases the chance of success by 1.

Number of successes required: The number of successes required depends on the item's complexity. There are four categories: Simple, standard, complex and exceptional. The referee may adjust these numbers based on conditions or materials.

Crafting Mastery: Artisan mastery is divided into four ranks: novice, competent, skilled, and master. Unlike other proficiencies, advancement is made through a certain number of items completed, plus some additional requirements, as explained on the following page.

Masterwork Pieces

These are objects whose making technique is very advanced and high-quality. A masterwork piece may possess better properties than usual, such as +1 to attack rolls and damage for weapons or 1 AC bonus for armor, at referee's discretion. Masterwork and magical properties are separate, but may stack together.

Artisan Rank Advancement Table

Rank	Requirements	Benefit
Novice	None	2-in-6 chance of success
Competent	7 items completed + 3rd Level	3-in-6 chance of success
Skilled	15 items completed + 6th Level + Special Quest	4-in-6 chance of success
Master	30 + items complete + 9th Level + Special Quest	5-in-6 chance of success, ability of creating masterwork pieces.

Disciplines

Multiple disciplines determine the type of items anyone would be able to create. Each discipline is learned and advanced separately (e.g. a character creating a sword while being a skilled weaponsmith has a 3-in-6 chance of success, but has a 2-in-6 chance if they are a novice armorer).

List of Disciplines:

- **Armorer:** Crafts metallic shields and armor.
- **Weaponsmith:** Forges melee weapons.
- **Bowyer/Fletcher:** Produces bows, crossbows, arrows, and bolts for ranged combat.
- **Leatherworker:** Creates leather armor, pouches, belts and similar gear.
- **Woodworker:** Shapes staves, clubs, poles, and wooden tools.
- **Blacksmith:** Makes essential metal tools, spikes, grappels, and similar hardware.
- **Jeweler:** Crafts rings, amulets, and fine items.
- **Alchemist:** Brews potions (non-magical), oils, powders, and other chemical substances.
- **Tinker:** Creates gears and constructs small mechanisms, traps, and intricate components.

Special Quests

Higher ranks may require a special quest to be achieved. Any referee may use the following as inspiration:

Special Quest Ideas Table

d6	Quest Idea
1	Find a master in a far-off place to teach you advanced techniques.
2	Seek rare materials in a dangerous and distant location to create an exotic piece.
3	Create a specific item at the commission of a wealthy patron.
4	Locate a lost technique or item in some ruins to replicate their making.
5	Defeat a rival artisan through competition or sabotage to prove superiority.
6	Join a specific guild through a show of skills or paying a fee.

Non-Weapon Proficiencies

Non-weapon proficiencies represent a character's knowledge and specialized training beyond combat. In the vein of these rule set, they will keep themselves as the theoretical knowledge a character acquires during the course of a campaign, whether consciously or subconsciously by the player's actions related to that specific field.

Assumed Knowledge vs Skill Checks

Unlike other types of skills presented in this booklet, non-weapon proficiencies are presented in two variants, that of assumed knowledge and skill checks, of which it will depend on the referee which of them fit their play style.

Assumed Knowledge means the proficiency defines what the character is reasonably expected to know or understand without rolling dice, instead of what they can actively attempt through a check. In this approach, proficiency functions as a permission and context tool. The character does not roll to see if they know something; they simply do, as long as it falls within the normal scope of the proficiency.

In contrast, skill checks represent a character's ability to actively attempt a task where success is uncertain and consequences matter. A check is rolled to determine whether the character can apply their training under pressure, difficulty, or risk

Based on that, the following rules for handling these options apply, at referee's discretion:

Skill Checks (Optional Rules): If the referee rules it, one can make a skill check, getting a -2 bonus on ability checks related to their proficiency.

Becoming Proficient: Characters become proficient in a field through meaningful involvement, either working on the field, learning with an expert or studying for at least 1 hour a day. After accumulating a specific number of days, the character then becomes proficient. A referee may choose the proficiency themselves or allow the player to choose.

Number of days required: At least 90 days of meaningful involvement are required to gain a specific proficiency.

Level Requirements: Additional to the days required, a character must be of 2nd level to acquire their first proficiency, additional proficiencies are gained in levels 4th, 6th and 8th, for a maximum of four proficiencies per character. The number of proficiencies learned are combined with the number of artisan and survival skills also learned.

Proficiency Groups: Proficiencies are classified in five groups: General, Cleric, Fighter, Magic-User and Thief. For any character whose class aligns to one of these groups (with the exception of general), the number of days required to become proficient is halved.

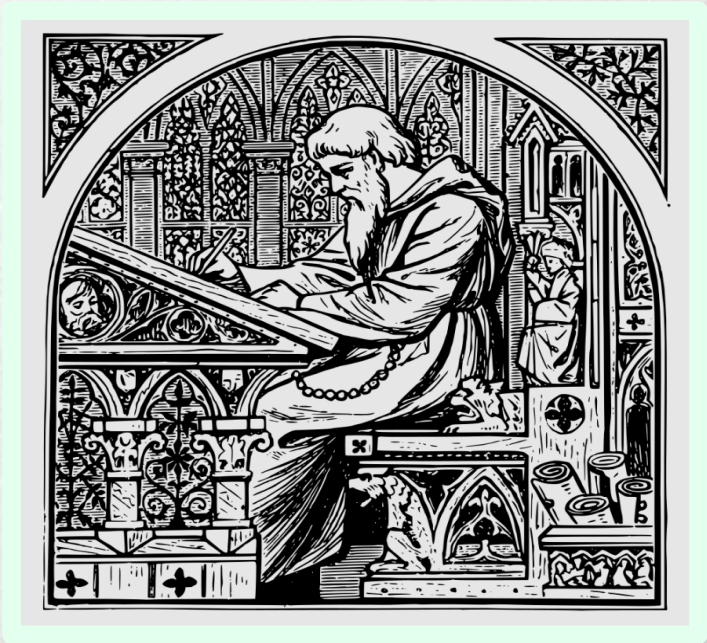
Per-skill Tracking: Training is recorded separately for each proficiency. Characters may advance on one proficiency per day.

Additional Proficiencies: If a character wishes to begin advancement in a new field beyond their limit, they must first abandon another. Characters must start from the beginning to recover a lost proficiency.

Proficiency Groups

General Proficiencies

General Proficiencies Table		
d8	Proficiency	Description
1	History	Knowledge of major events, cultures, and timelines.
2	Geography	Understanding of lands, borders, climates, and map interpretation.
3	Politics	Knowledge of noble houses, symbols, and political lineages.
4	Philosophy	Logic, ethics, metaphysics, and schools of thought.
5	Mathematics	Arithmetic, geometry, and abstract reasoning.
6	Botanic	Theoretical knowledge of flora, fauna, and ecosystems.
7	Anthropology	Customs, traditions, and social structures of various peoples.
8	Bureaucracy	Knowledge of administrative systems, laws and the internal logic of governments or institutions.

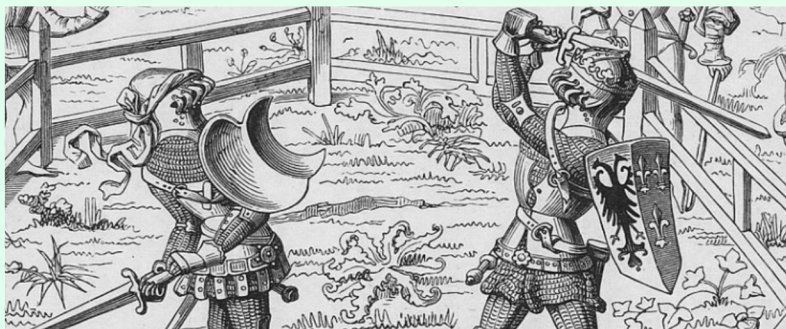


Cleric Proficiencies

Cleric Proficiencies Table

d12	Proficiency	Description
1	Theology	Study of divine hierarchies, doctrines, and sacred teachings.
2	Mythology	Knowledge of creation stories, heroic sagas, and divine narratives.
3	Iconography	Understanding of sacred symbols, motifs, and religious imagery.
4	Ethics	Study of moral systems, virtues, and ethical dilemmas. It helps a character analyze right and wrong through structured reasoning.
5	Cosmology	Knowledge of spiritual realms, afterlives, and divine planes.
6	Demonology	Study of fiendish hierarchies, contracts, and infernal lore.
7	Angelology	Knowledge of celestial beings, their duties, and their manifestations.
8	Sacred Languages	Study of ancient or divine tongues used in holy texts.
9	Relic Lore	Knowledge of holy artifacts, their origins, and their significance.
10	Ritual Studies	Understanding of the structure, symbolism, and purpose of sacred rites.
11	Eschatology	Study of end-times doctrines, apocalyptic visions, and final-judgment beliefs.
12	Sacred Geometry	Understanding of symbolic mathematical patterns believed to reflect divine order.





Fighter Proficiencies

Fighter Proficiencies Table

d12	Proficiency	Description
1	Military Ranks	Hierarchical structures within armies, including titles, duties, and chains of command.
2	Battle Tactics	Battlefield maneuvers, formations, and engagement strategies.
3	Siege Tactics	Offensive and defensive strategies used during sieges.
4	Armor Lore	Knowledge of armor types, materials, and construction principles.
5	Weapons Lore	Study of weapon designs, classifications, and the philosophies behind their use.
6	Logistics	Understanding of supply chains, provisioning, and the movement of troops and resources.
7	Martial Arts	Knowledge of combat traditions, stances, and theoretical principles.
8	Heraldry	Coats of arms, banners, and symbolic markings used by noble and military houses.
9	Horsemanship	Horse taming, raising, breeding and riding principles.
10	Fortifications	Knowledge of defensive structures, their design logic, construction techniques and their strategic purpose.
11	Laws of War	Study of codes, customs, and ethical frameworks governing conflict.
12	Beast Lore	Knowledge of dangerous creatures, their instincts, ecology and their behavioral patterns.



Magic-User Proficiencies

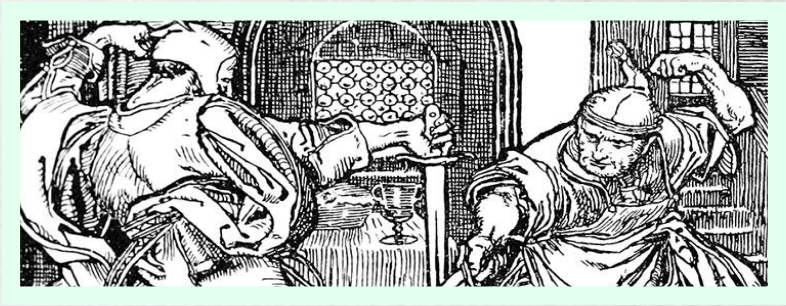
Magic-User Proficiencies Table

d12	Proficiency	Description
1	Arcane Theory	Study of the fundamental principles that govern magical energy, ley lines, and arcane interaction.
2	Alchemy	Knowledge of symbolic transmutation, elemental correspondences, and the philosophical underpinnings of alchemical change.
3	Planar Cosmology	Study of the structure, laws, and relationships between the various planes of existence.
4	Runes and Sigils	Understanding of magical symbols, their encoded meanings, and the logic behind their construction.
5	Magical Constructs	Knowledge of artificially created magical entities, bindings, and arcane frameworks.
6	Spellcraft	Study of how spells are designed, layered, and balanced within the arcane system.
7	Astrology	Knowledge of celestial bodies, constellations, and their influence on magical currents.
8	Enchantments	Understanding of the theory behind imbuing objects or beings with magical properties.
9	Divination	Methods used to perceive hidden truths, patterns, or future possibilities.
10	Curses and Hexes	Knowledge of malefic magical effects, their symbolic structures, and the principles that bind them.
11	Minor Arcana	Understanding of the inner workings of the mind and consciousness
12	Major Arcana	Understanding of the physical and chemical rules and phenomena of the universe.

Thief Proficiencies

Thief Proficiencies Table

d12	Proficiency	Description
1	Forgery	The methods, materials, and stylistic cues used in creating false documents.
2	Musical Instrument	Knowledge of how to play one specific instrument.
3	Urban Lore	Understanding of city layouts, social strata, and the hidden rhythms of urban life.
4	Criminality	Illicit economies, gang structures, and the logic behind unlawful behavior.
5	Smuggling	Covert transport routes, concealment strategies, and the economics of contraband and how to engage in it.
6	Poisons and Toxins	Knowledge of harmful substances, their symptoms, how and where to obtain them.
7	Game Theory	Study of probability, strategy, and decision-making in competitive scenarios.
8	Con Artistry	Confidence schemes, psychological manipulation, and the structure of classic swindles and scams.
9	Merchant Customs	Understanding of trade etiquette, financial practices and commercial expectations across cultures.
10	Gem Appraising	Knowledge of gemstone types, grading principles, and theoretical valuation.
11	Disposing	Knowledge regarding how the networks, intermediaries, and methods used to make items or people “disappear”.
12	Lip Reading	How to interpret speech by observing mouth movements and facial cues.



Survival Proficiency

Survival skills encompass the knowledge and practiced techniques needed to endure hostile environments, secure basic necessities, and navigate wilderness dangers. These skills take place during the wilderness travel phase, where a player may send their character to hunt, gather, and in this instance, perform certain additional tasks within the umbrella of survival skills.

Important Assumptions

Before we begin, it is important to point out the important key assumptions of what a character knows when traveling the wilderness and where survival skills are applied. For starters, due to the nature of the adventurer profession, any character knows the basics of camping, regardless of class, these basics include how to start a fire, purify water, set up a tent, cook a meal, tie knot, among many others. Survival skills refer to more costly and time consuming tasks, the kind of which require at least the entire day to accomplish, hence why they take place during the wilderness travel phase.

Survival Checks

Any survival skill is determined by doing a d6 check with a 1-in-6 chance of success. The chance of success increases by the amount of days spent in the wilderness, according to the following principles:

Days Spent at the Wilderness: Every 15 consecutive days spent at the wilderness a character obtains a -1 bonus to the survival check, for a maximum of -3 (Ranger characters can get up to -4).



Survival Skills Descriptions

Pathfinding: It allows the character to look for the right path to their destination if they are currently lost in direction.

Gear Repairing: The character sharpens weapons and armor. A Broken weapon or armor is repaired on a success. Only one piece of gear may be repaired at a time

Tending Wounds: The character may tend wounds, provided they have bandages, proper herbs or other required objects set by the Referee. On a success, the wounded character recovers 1d3 hit points after a full night of sleep.

Hunting: When hunting, success means encountering animals which may be suitable for eating (if they can be caught!). This is in addition to the normal chance of random encounters.

Foraging: Seeking for herbs, fruits, nuts, etc. On a success, the character finds enough food or water for 1d3 people that day, specific herbs or other artisan materials.

Treating Illness: The character may treat illnesses, provided they have proper remedies or other required objects set by the referee. On a success, the character treats status ailments like poison, paralysis or diseases (assuming they can be cured).

Languages

Although one could start at level 1 knowing additional languages depending on their INT score, realistically exposure to a language usually ends up with one finally learning it, the following rules are to be followed to adjudicate learning new languages.

Number of Languages to Learn: The maximum number of languages one can learn, aside from those determined at level 1, is determined by INT score, according to the table below: Once all allowed languages are learned, one would have to forget one to learn a new one.

Additional Languages Table	
INT Score	# Of additional Languages
1	1
2	2
3	3
4	4

Learning New Languages: One can learn a new language by either spending days in a location where that language is mostly spoken or by studying with a professor for at least 1 hour a day.



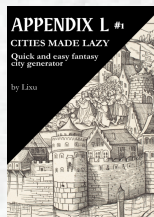
Language Learning Time Table	
Days	Language Expertise
0	Not able to communicate
90	Basic Sentences
180	Conversational Level
365	Academic Level

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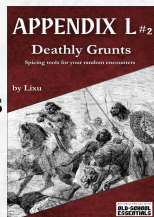
Appendix L#1: Cities Made Lazy

Bring your worlds to life in minutes with *Cities Made Lazy*, a fast, flexible city-building toolkit for referees who want rich detail without the prep grind. Whether your players wander off the map or you're shaping a new realm from scratch, this supplement gives you natural landmarks, governments, trade profiles, defenses, crime levels, threats, layout guidance, and more.



Appendix L#2: Deathly Grunts

If you want your low-level foes to feel like more than sword fodder, *Deathly Grunts* arms you with flavorful tools to elevate every encounter. Inside you'll find warband motivations, monster encounter details, tactical combat tables covering everything from explosives to magic, and six fully-realized warband commanders to serve as memorable villains.



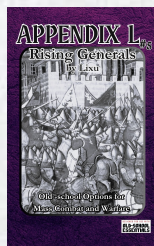
Appendix L#4: Savage Scavengers

For tables where harvesting monsters is a tradition, or a compulsion, *Savage Scavengers* provides a complete system for extracting materials and brewing potent concoctions in *Old-School Essentials* and other classic RPGs, with elemental alchemy rules, chance-based potion crafting, recipes for iconic magical brews, and exhaustive loot lists for nearly every B/X creature.



Appendix L#5: Rising Generals

When adventurers rise to power, the world should rise to meet them. *Rising Generals* expands your old-school campaign into the realm of warfare, domain management, and high-stakes strategy. Streamlined mass-combat rules, siege and naval warfare systems, logistics and supply mechanics, and optional gritty war realities let you run battles, invasions, and political conflicts with ease. Whether defending a fledgling barony or commanding armies across land and sea, this guide turns high-level play into epic, world-shaping storytelling.



Notes

